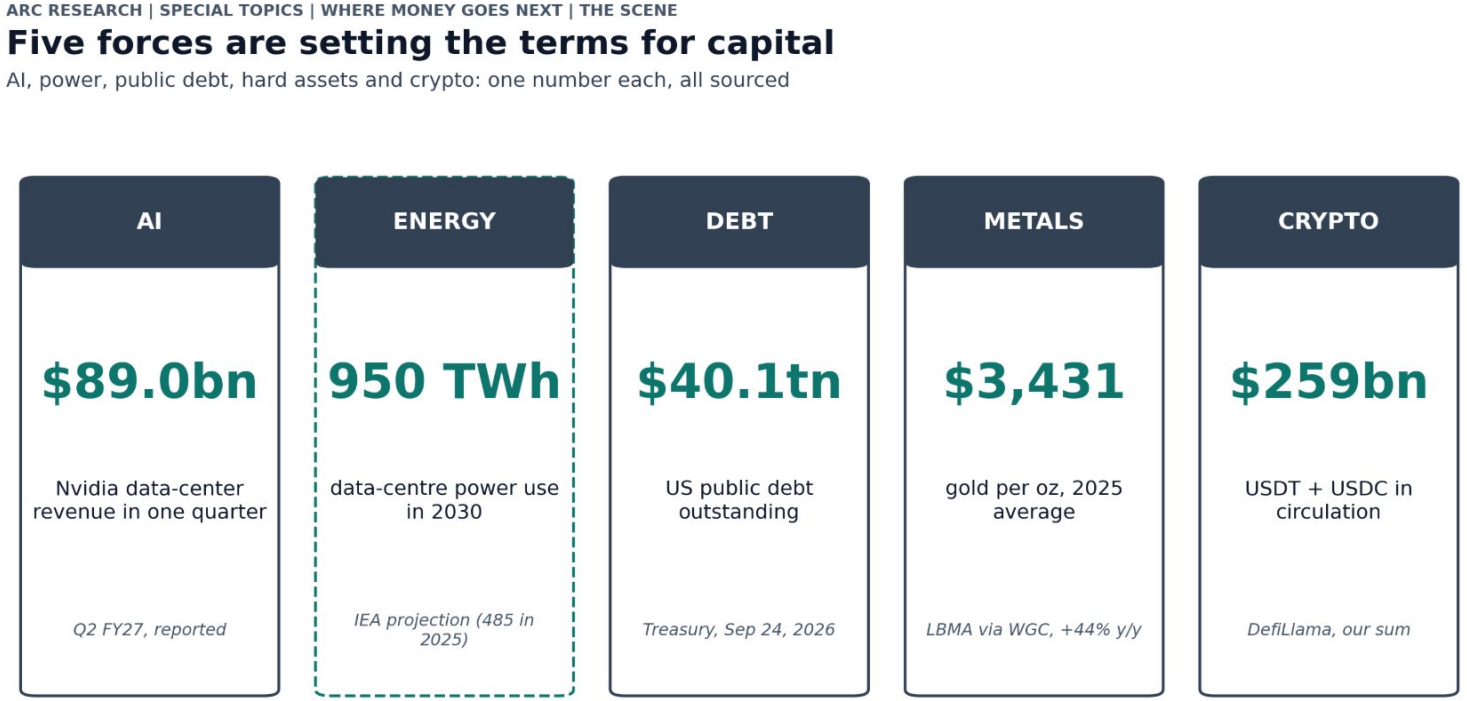
ARC RESEARCH · SPECIAL TOPICS

Where money goes next

AI, energy, debt, metals and crypto: how capital may be positioned

Sep 28, 2026 · Educational purposes only, not investment advice

Five forces are setting the terms for capital



SO WHAT

AI is the demand engine

Power and metals are the bottlenecks

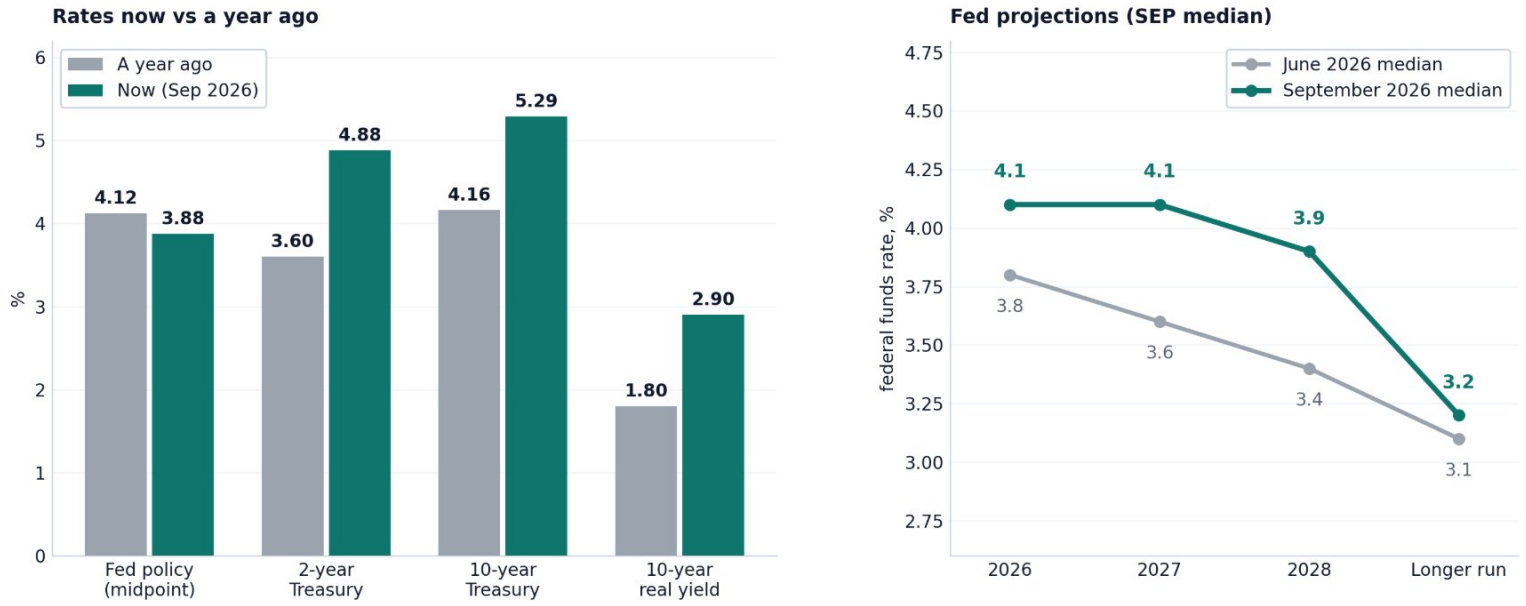
Debt pushes investors toward hard assets

Rates are rising again, and long yields lead

ARC RESEARCH | SPECIAL TOPICS | WHERE MONEY GOES NEXT | MARKET ENVIRONMENT: RATES

The Fed hiked to 3.75-4.00% and the 10-year yield hit 5.29%

Treasury yields are 1.1-1.3 points above a year ago; the Fed's median now sees 4.1% at end-2026 and a higher long-run rate (3.2%)



Source: Federal Reserve FOMC statement and Summary of Economic Projections (Sep 16, 2026; 12-0 vote); U.S. Treasury daily par yield curve (Sep 30, 2026; year-ago Sep 30, 2025); 10-year real yield = FRED DFII10 (Sep 28, 2026; year-ago as read by our researcher). Policy rate = midpoint of target range (3.875% now; 4.125% a year ago, range 4.00-4.25%). SEP = median FOMC projection for the federal funds rate, year-end.

SO WHAT

Fed hiked 25 bp to 3.75-4.00%

10-year 5.29% vs 4.16% a year ago

Real 10-year yield: 2.90% vs 1.80%

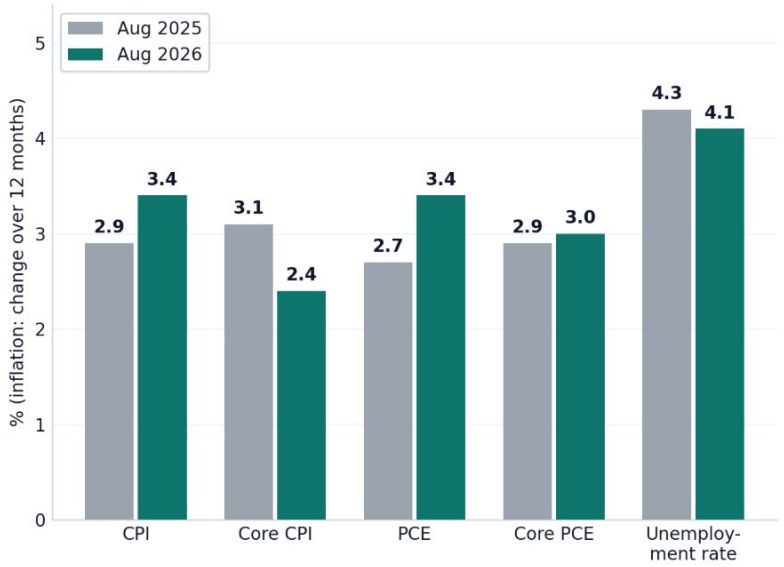
Inflation is back near 3.4%; growth and jobs hold

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Inflation is back near 3.4% on energy while growth and jobs hold

Headline CPI and PCE are 3.4%; core CPI is 2.4% but core PCE is 3.0%; unemployment 4.1%; the S&P 500 is up 15% in a year

Inflation and unemployment



Growth, jobs, stocks and oil

7,671
S&P 500 close Sep 29, +15% vs 6,688 a year earlier
FRED; Yahoo Finance

+2.2%
Q2 2026 real GDP, annualized
BEA, Sep 30

+162k
August payrolls; wages +3.1% over 12 months
BLS, Sep 4

$96
WTI crude spot, Sep 29; gasoline CPI +27.4% in 12 months
FRED; BLS

Source: BLS CPI (Aug 2026, released Sep 11) and Employment Situation (Aug, released Sep 4); BEA PCE (Aug, released Sep 30) and GDP third estimate Q2 (Sep 30); S&P 500 close Sep 29, 2026 (FRED, S&P Dow Jones Indices) vs Sep 30, 2025 (Yahoo Finance); WTI spot Sep 29 (FRED). Year-ago inflation and unemployment are August 2025 readings (first-release basis). Core CPI and core PCE use different baskets and weights.

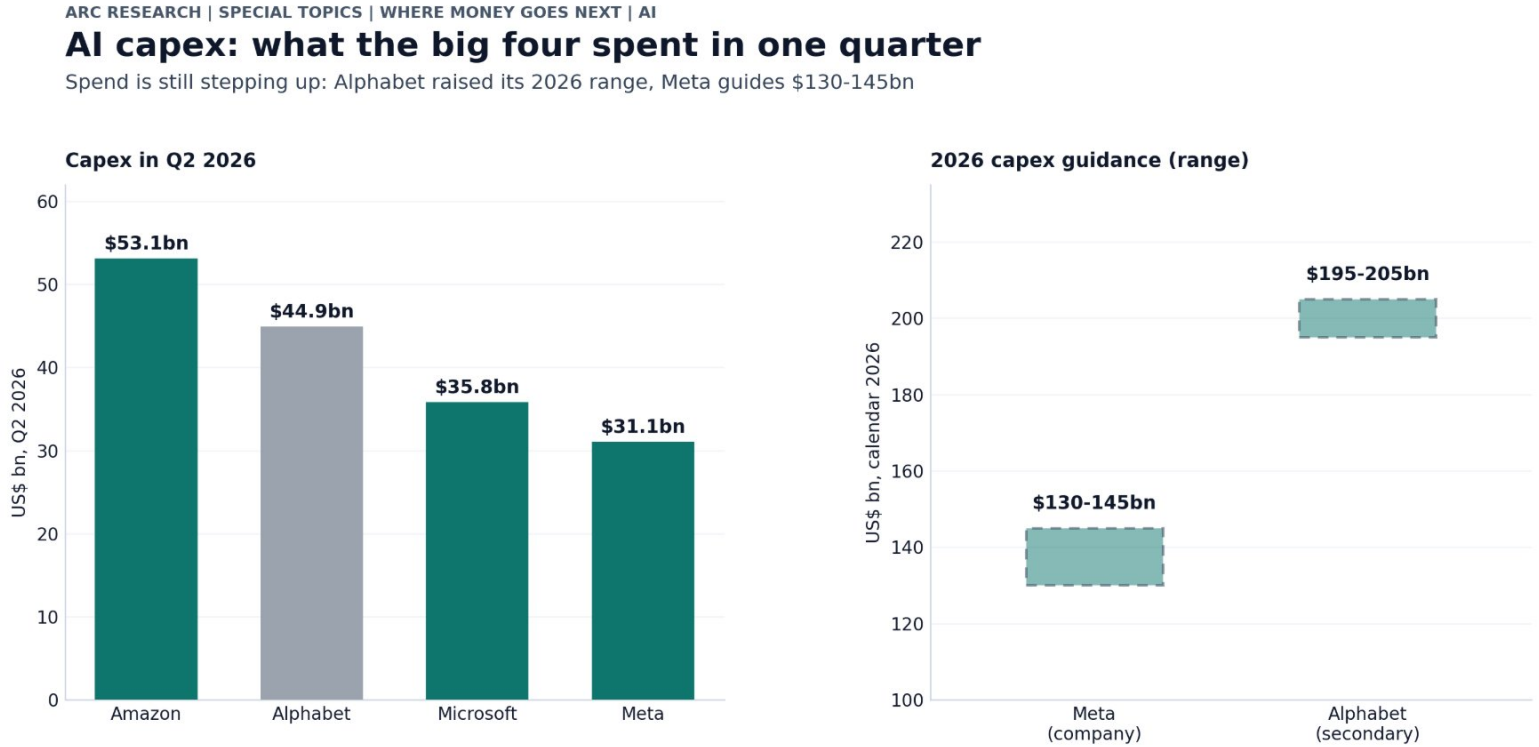
SO WHAT

CPI and PCE 3.4%, driven by energy

Unemployment 4.1%, GDP +2.2%

S&P 500 7,671, up 15% in a year

AI capex is the engine, and it keeps rising



SO WHAT

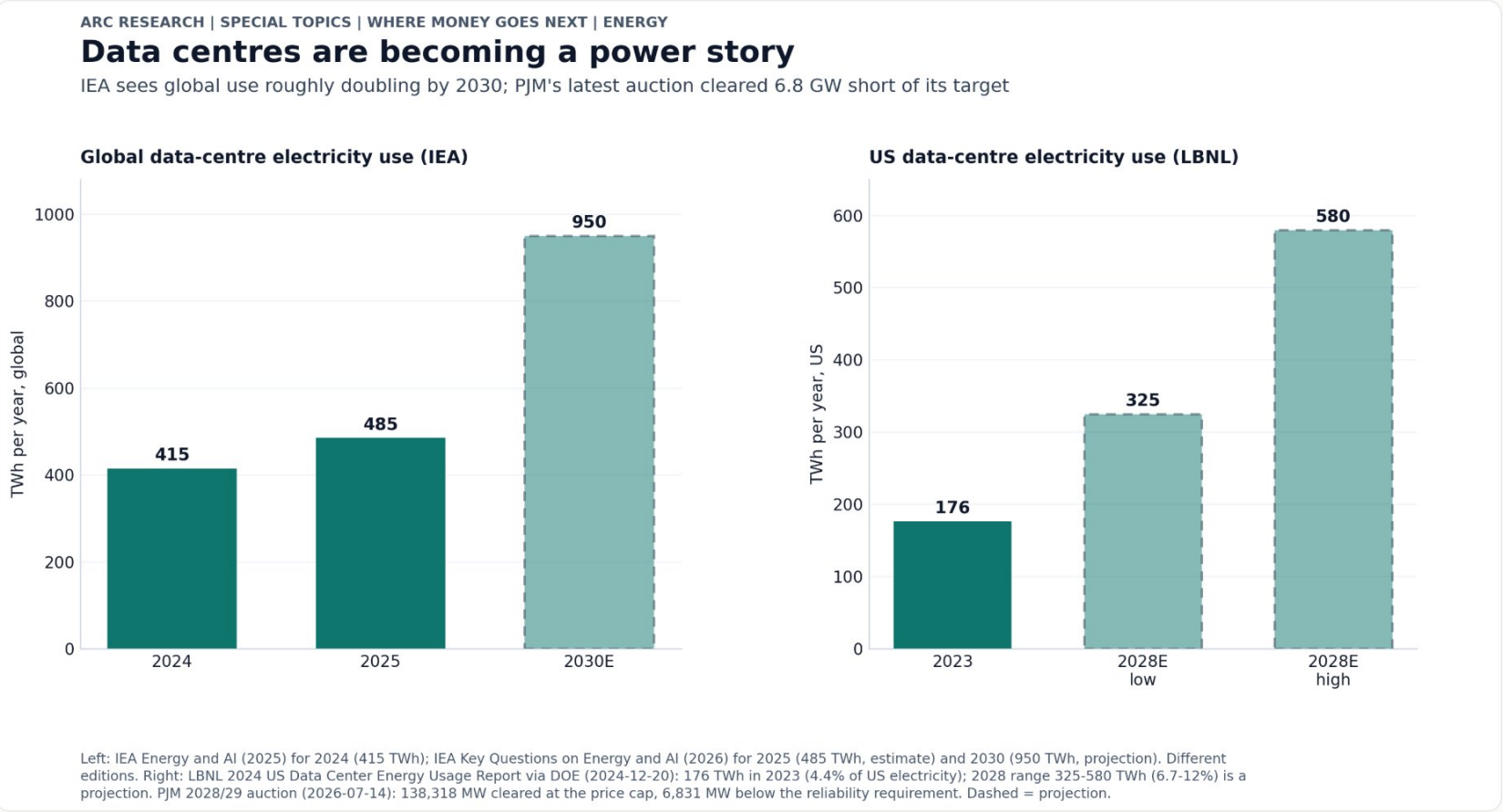
Each of four firms spent $31-53bn in Q2

Alphabet lifted its 2026 range to $195-205bn

Meta guides $130-145bn for 2026

ENERGY

AI is now a power story



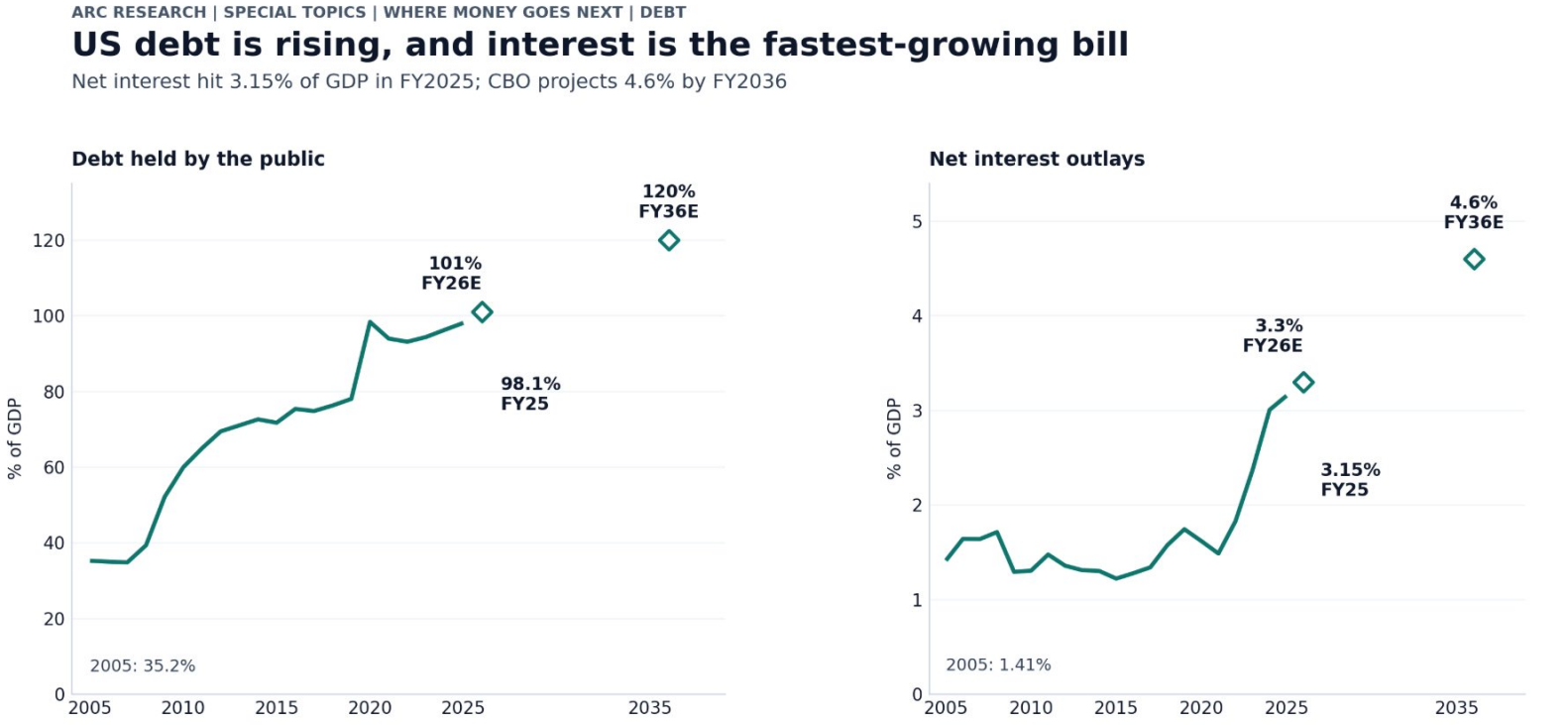
SO WHAT

Global data-centre use may double by 2030

PJM's auction cleared 6.8 GW short

Why nuclear: ran at 91% of capacity in 2025

Interest costs are the fastest-growing bill



Left: federal debt held by the public, % of GDP, fiscal years (FRED FYPUGDA188S). Right: net interest outlays, % of GDP (FRED FYOIGDA188S; FY2025 = $970bn, FRED FYOINT). Hollow diamonds = CBO Budget and Economic Outlook 2026-2036 (Feb 2026) projections for FY2026 and FY2036 only; no path drawn between them. Total public debt outstanding $40.07tn on 2026-09-24 (Treasury Debt to the Penny); IMF WEO Apr 2026 gross general-government debt, 2026: Japan 204%, US 126%, France 118%, UK 104%.

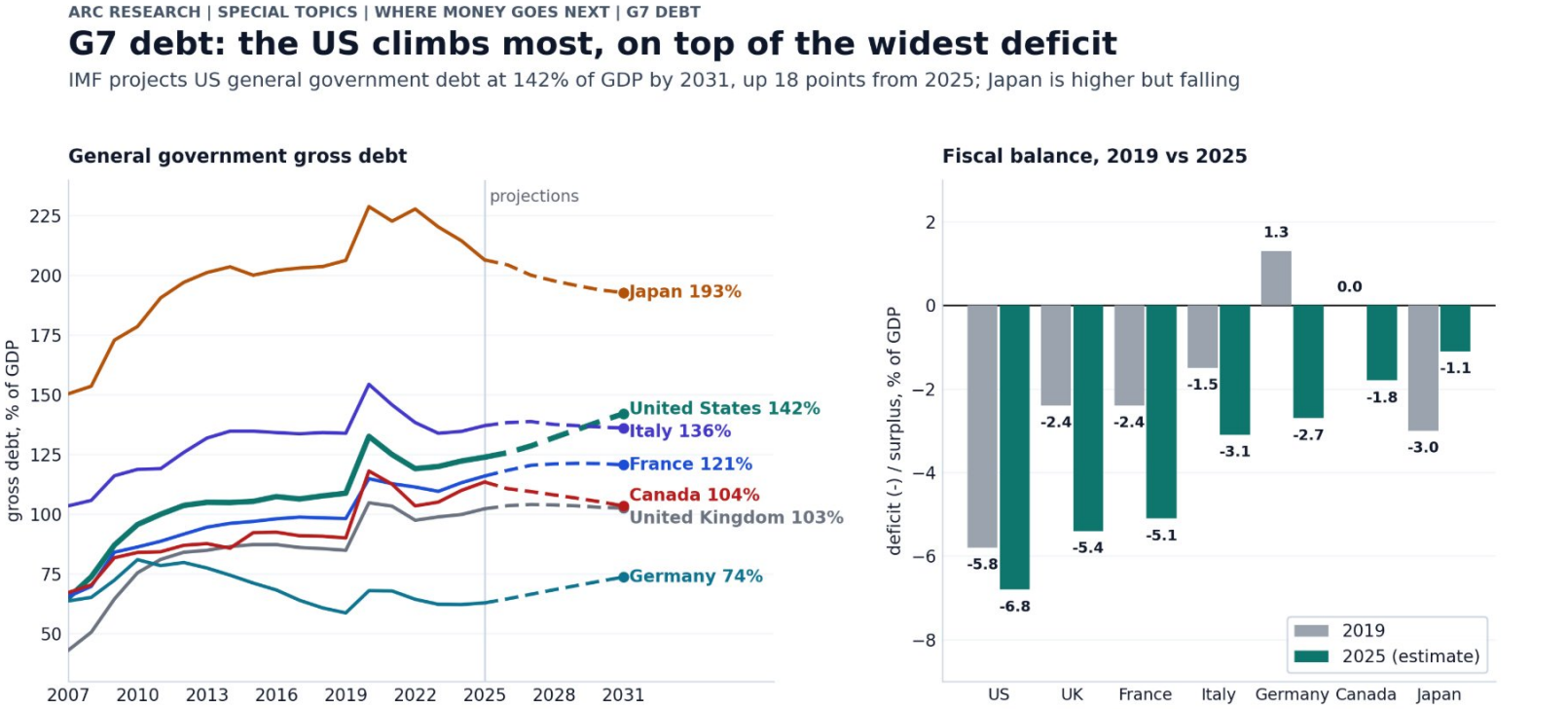
SO WHAT

Debt held by the public: 98% of GDP

Net interest: 3.15% of GDP, 4.6% by FY36 (CBO)

Total debt: $40.1tn on Sep 24

G7 debt: the US is on the steepest path



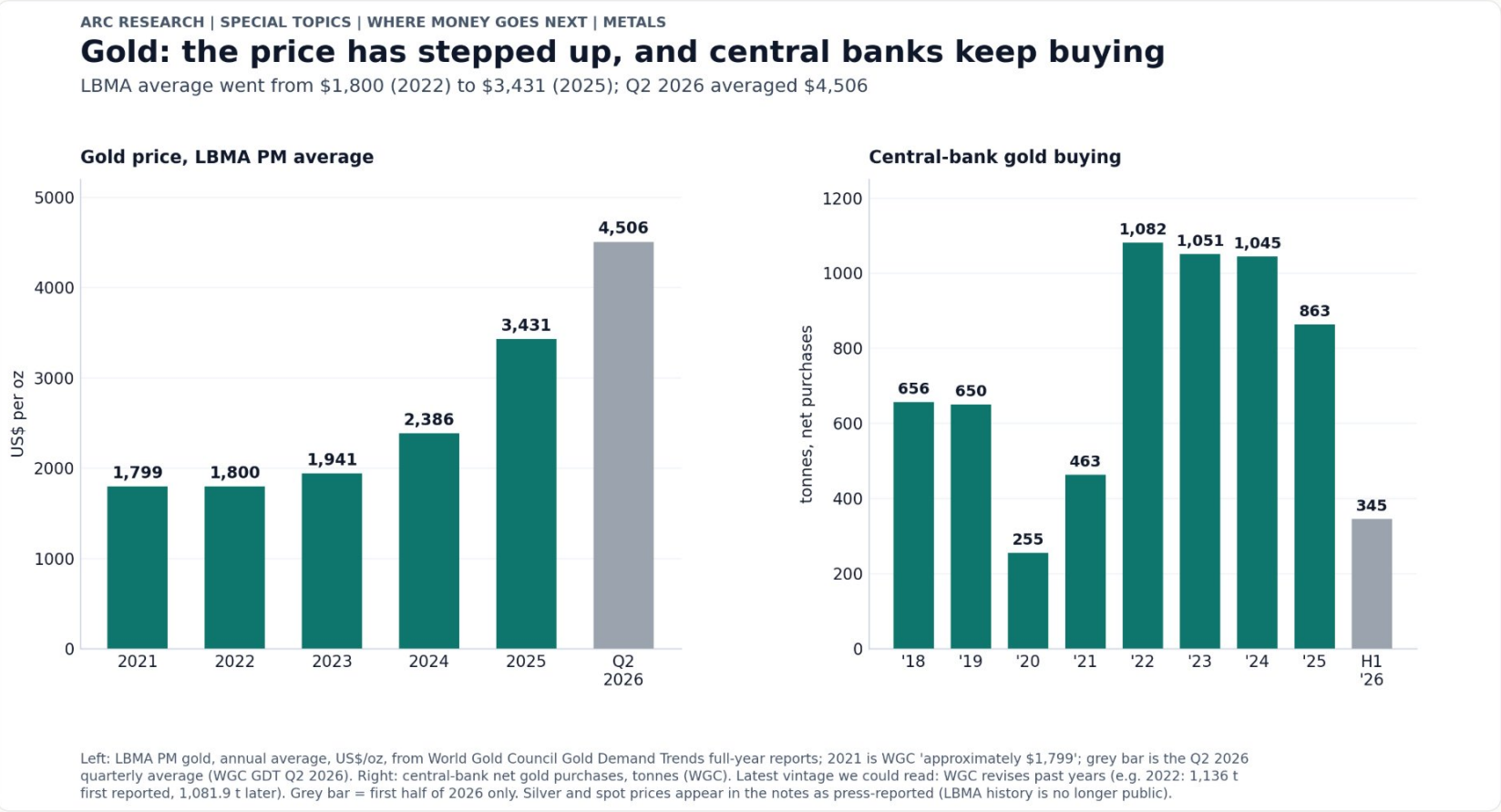
SO WHAT

US debt: 124% of GDP in 2025, 142% by 2031

US deficit 6.8% of GDP, widest in the G7

Japan 207% but falling; Germany 63%

Gold's price stepped up; central-bank buying stays high



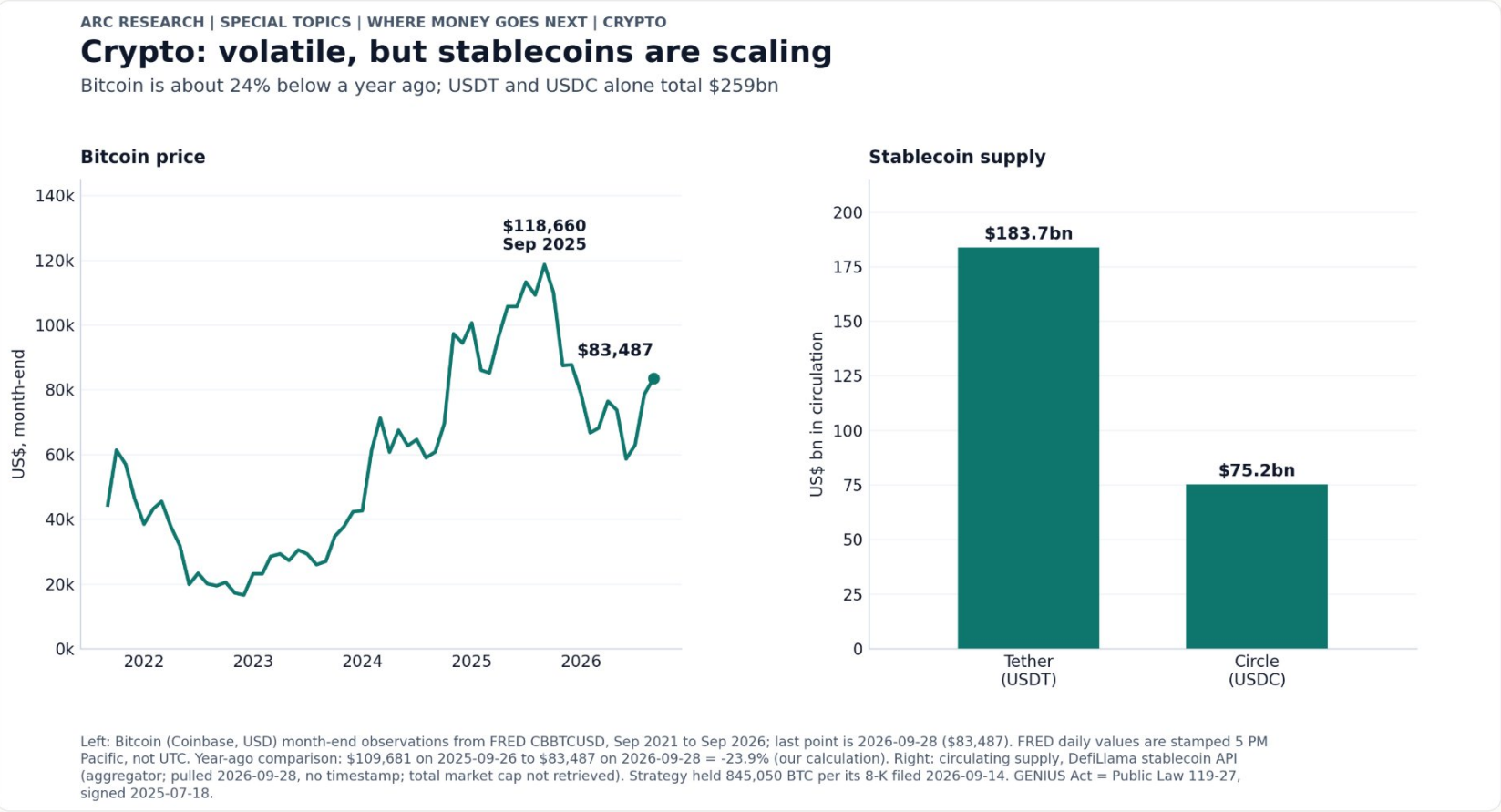
SO WHAT

Gold averaged $3,431 in 2025, +44%

Central banks bought 345 t in H1 2026, slower than 2022-24

Silver: 2025 deficit 46.3 Moz (press-reported)

Crypto is volatile, but stablecoins are scaling



Left: Bitcoin (Coinbase, USD) month-end observations from FRED CBBTCUSD, Sep 2021 to Sep 2026; last point is 2026-09-28 ($83,487). FRED daily values are stamped 5 PM Pacific, not UTC. Year-ago comparison: $109,681 on 2025-09-26 to $83,487 on 2026-09-28 = -23.9% (our calculation). Right: circulating supply, DefiLlama stablecoin API (aggregator; pulled 2026-09-28, no timestamp; total market cap not retrieved). Strategy held 845,050 BTC per its 8-K filed 2026-09-14. GENIUS Act = Public Law 119-27, signed 2025-07-18.

SO WHAT

Bitcoin: $83,487, down 24% in a year

USDT + USDC supply: $259bn

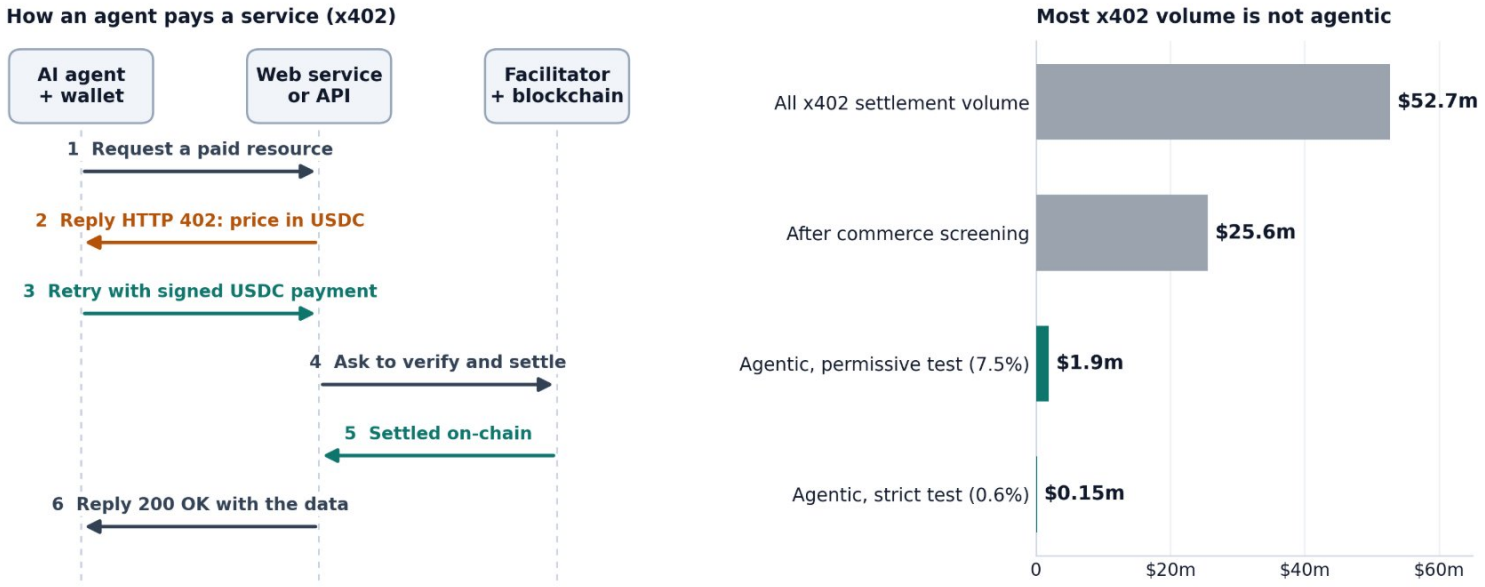
GENIUS Act became law in July 2025

Agents can pay in stablecoins; volume is still small

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Agents can pay in stablecoins over HTTP; real agent volume is still small

x402 has settled about $52.7m since May 2025; TRM Labs finds only 0.6-7.5% of screened commerce volume looks agentic



Source: left, schematic of the x402 payment flow (Coinbase x402 documentation and x402.org); the price is illustrative. Right: TRM Labs, 'Who's Actually Paying? Measuring AI Agent Payments Onchain' (Sep 9, 2026): about $52.7m across 198.9m settlement transactions via known x402 facilitators, May 2025 to mid-2026; $25.62m remained after TRM's commerce screening; agentic share of that screened volume 7.5% (permissive test) and 0.6% (strict test). Agentic dollar amounts = screened volume x share (our calculation). Other trackers count transactions differently and are not comparable.

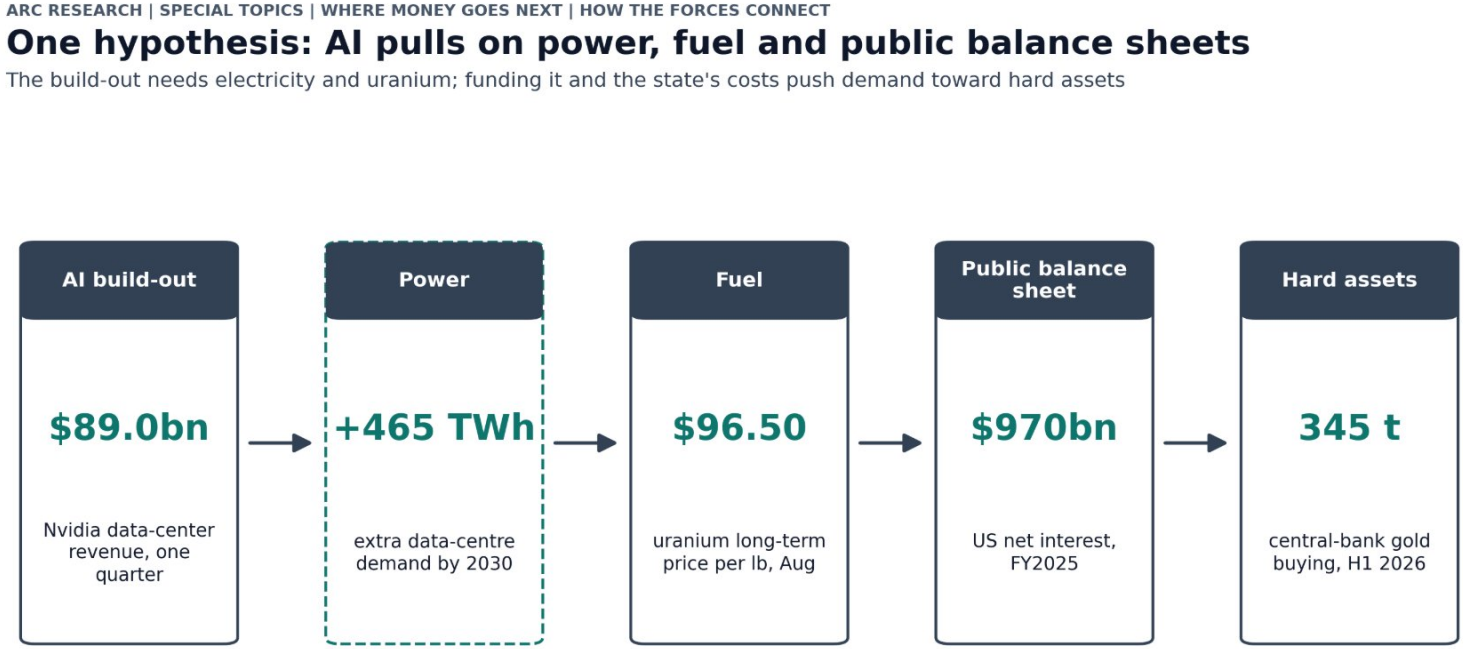
SO WHAT

x402 lets an agent pay per request in USDC

About $52.7m settled since May 2025

Only 0.6-7.5% of screened volume looks agentic

One hypothesis: AI pulls on power, fuel, balance sheets



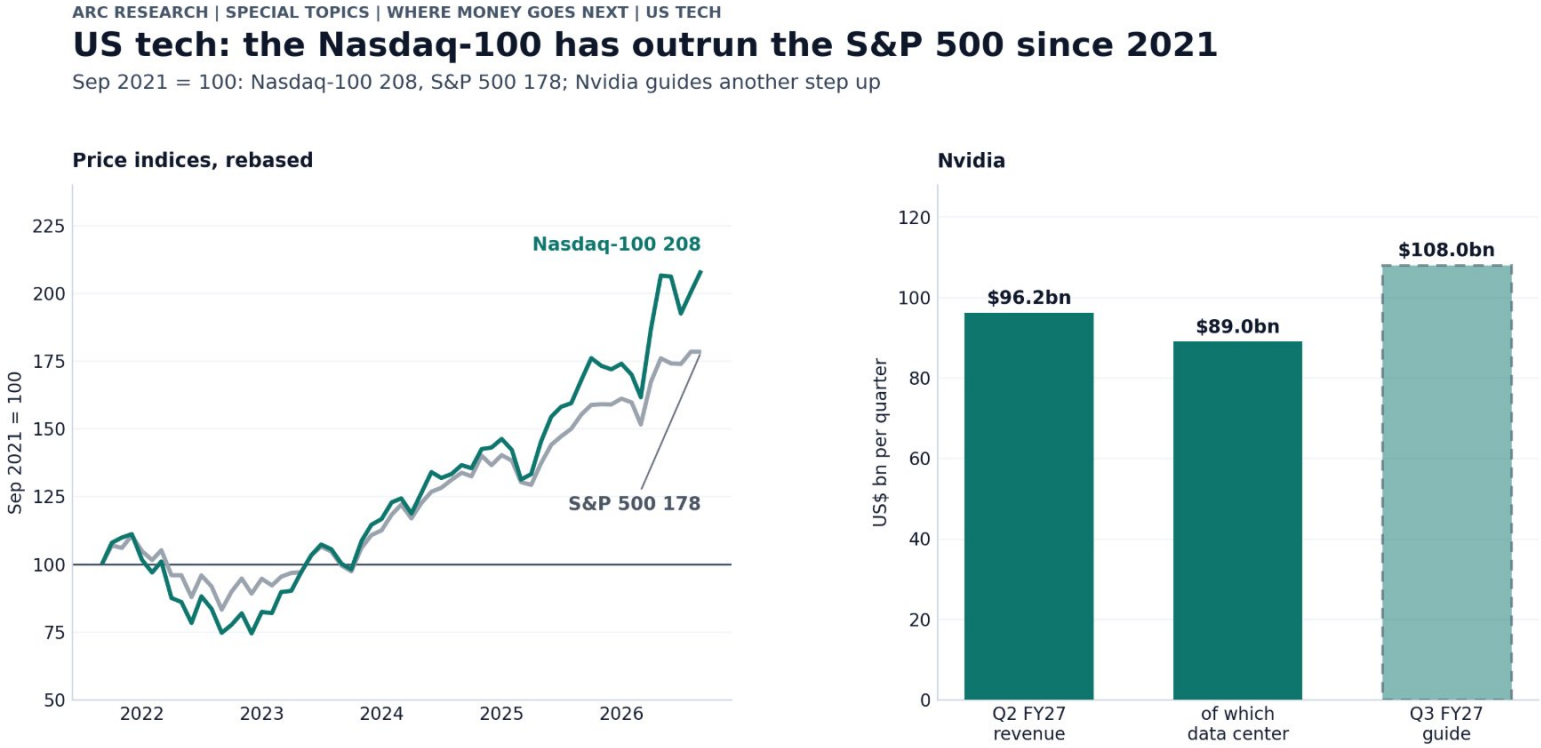
SO WHAT

The build-out needs power first

Fuel and metals follow the power

Funding costs push toward hard assets

US tech: keep the exposure



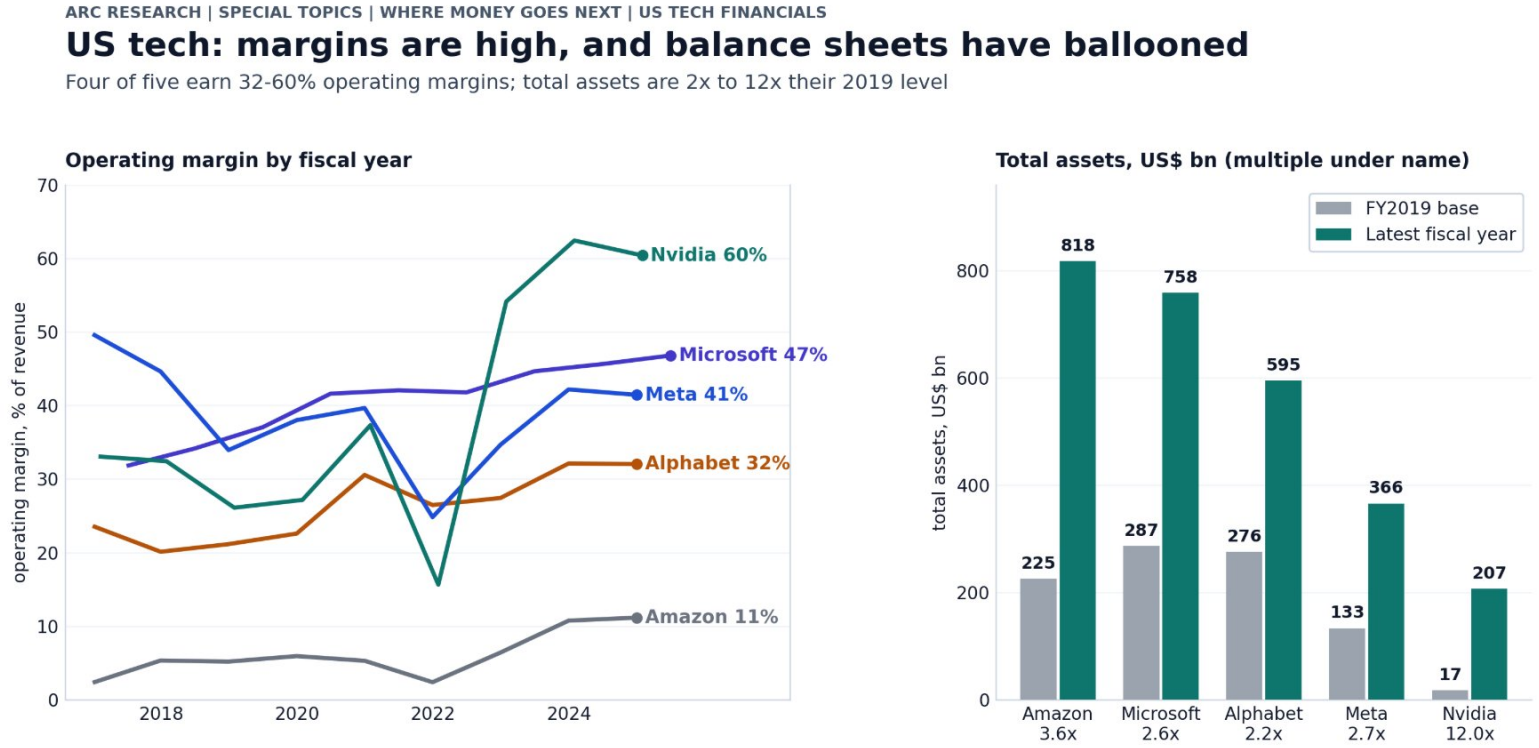
SO WHAT

Nasdaq-100 208 vs S&P 500 178 since Sep 2021

Nvidia data center: $89.0bn in one quarter

S&P 500 forward P/E: 19.2x

Big margins, and balance sheets 2x to 12x larger



Source: company 10-K filings via SEC EDGAR XBRL companyfacts API (data.sec.gov), annual facts, US$, fiscal years as reported and plotted at fiscal-year-end (Microsoft June; Alphabet, Amazon, Meta December; Nvidia late January, so its FY2026 ended in Jan 2026). Operating margin = operating income / revenue (our calculation). Right: base = first fiscal year ending Jun 2019 to Jan 2020; growth multiple = latest / base total assets (our calculation). Latest year: Microsoft FY2026 (Jun), Nvidia FY2026 (Jan), Alphabet, Amazon and Meta FY2025 (Dec). Operating margin is used because net income includes non-operating gains at Alphabet and Amazon.

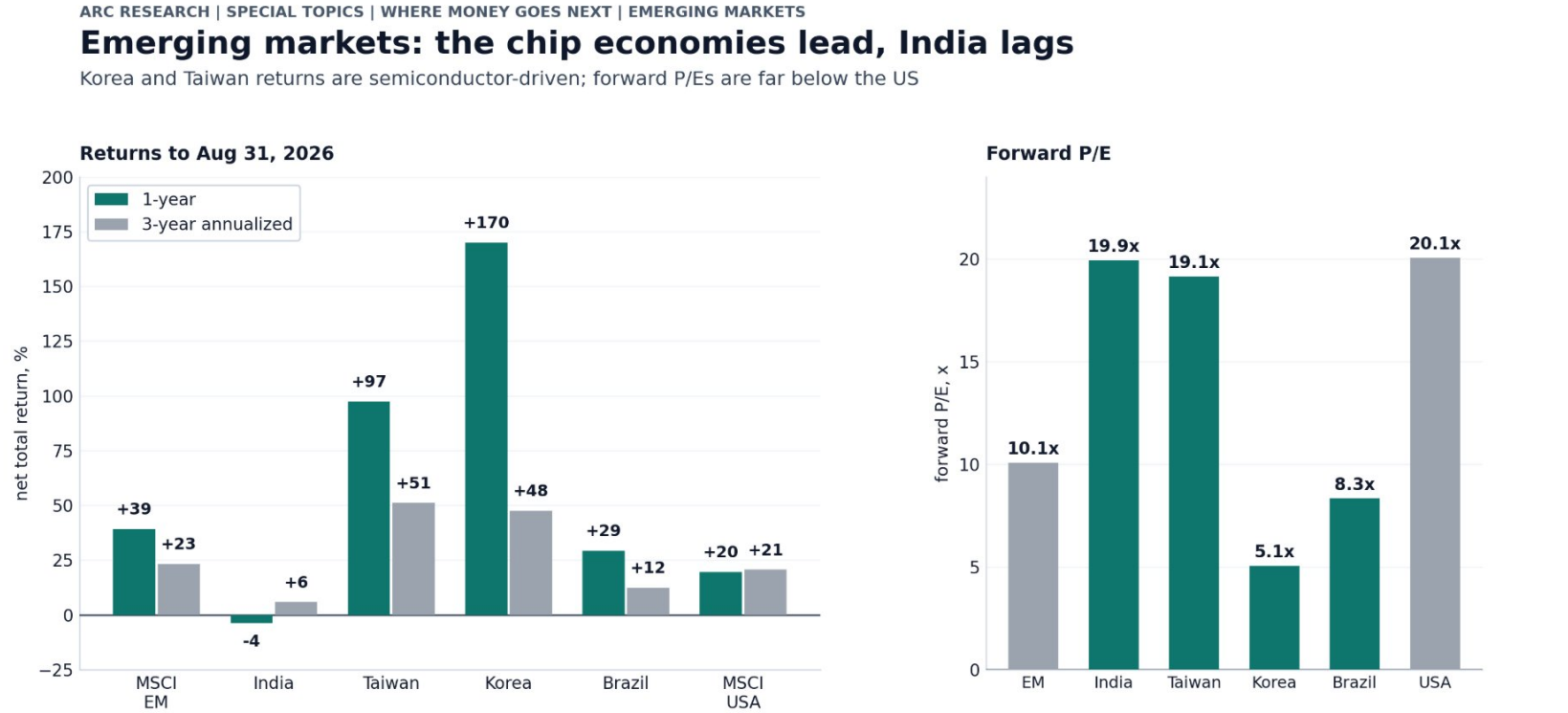
SO WHAT

Nvidia margin 60%, Microsoft 47%, Amazon 11%

Amazon assets $818bn, Microsoft $758bn

Nvidia assets 12x in six years, from $17bn

Emerging markets: chip economies lead, India lags



MSCI factsheets as of 2026-08-31, net total return in USD; 3-year figures annualized; P/E Fwd as printed by MSCI. Read through a summarizer, then a second independent read confirmed Korea (169.96 / 47.56, P/E Fwd 5.06) and MSCI EM (39.25 / 23.23, 10.07). Very large moves and low multiples are consistent with the factsheets but worth checking against the PDFs. Weights in MSCI EM: Taiwan 27.4%, Korea 20.8%, China 20.6%, India 11.3%, Brazil 3.9%; TSMC 15.1%, Samsung 7.2%, SK Hynix 5.5%.

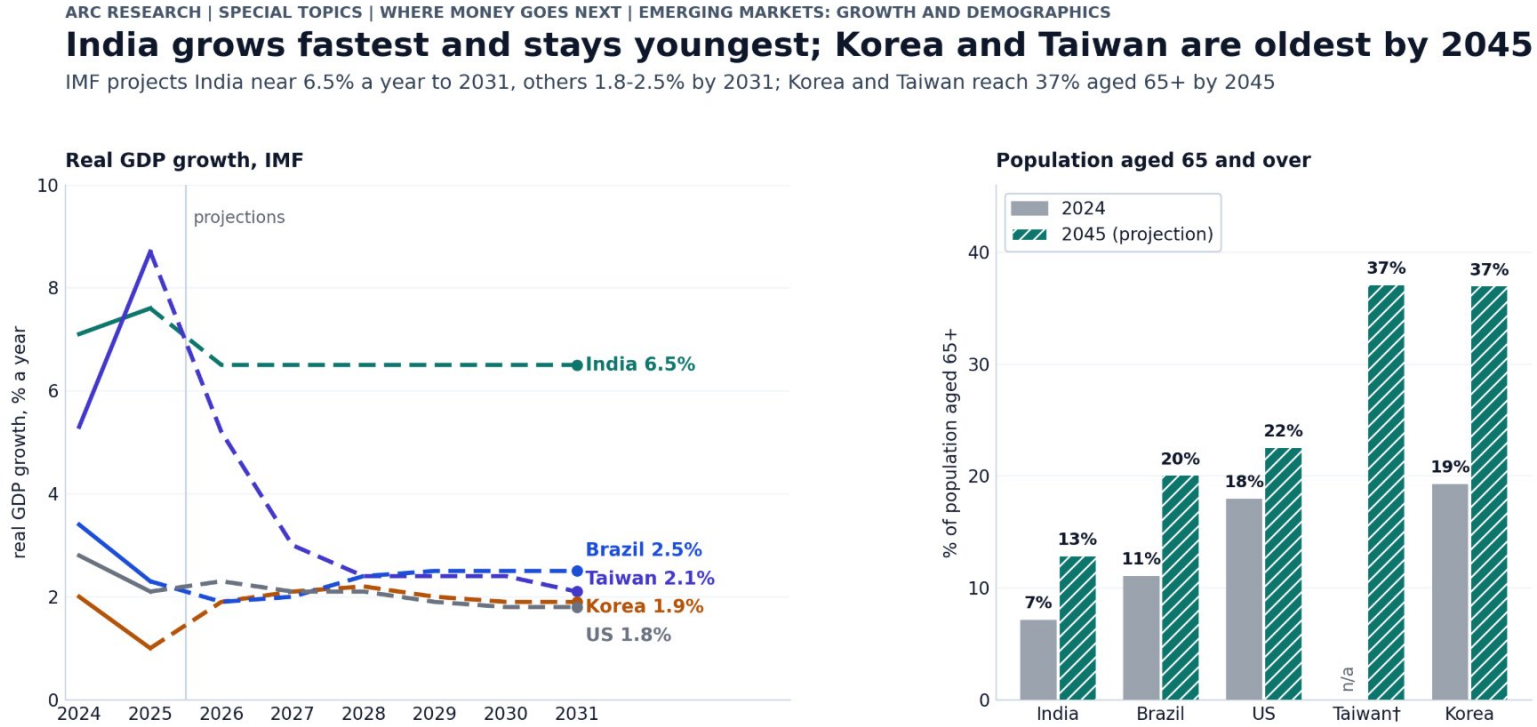
SO WHAT

Korea +170%, Taiwan +97% in one year

India: -3.8% in one year

EM forward P/E 10.1x vs USA 20.1x

India grows fastest; North Asia ages fastest



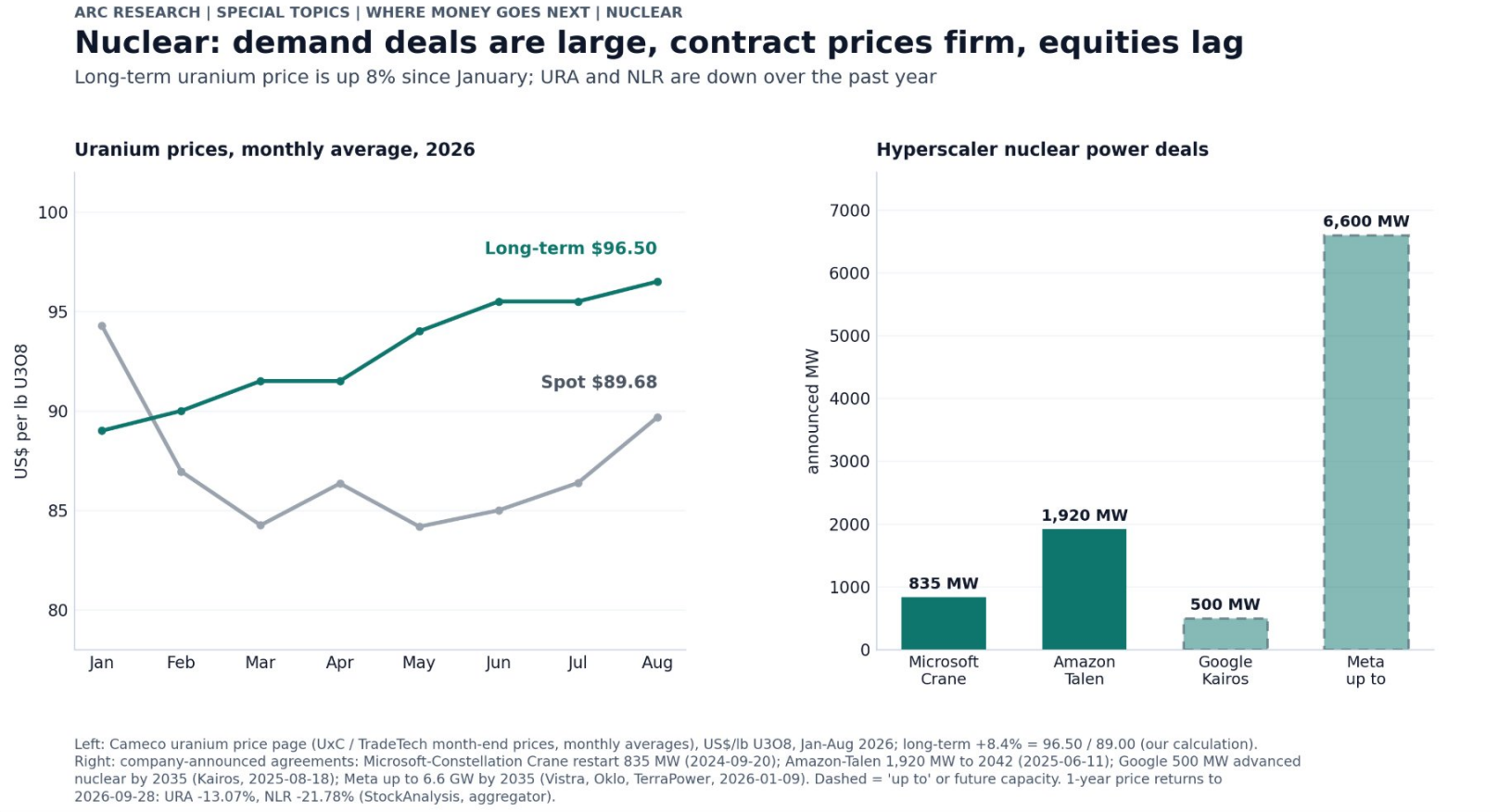
SO WHAT

India: 6.5% a year growth projected to 2031

India 65+ share: 7% now, 13% in 2045

Korea and Taiwan: 37% aged 65+ by 2045

Nuclear: deals are large, equities have lagged



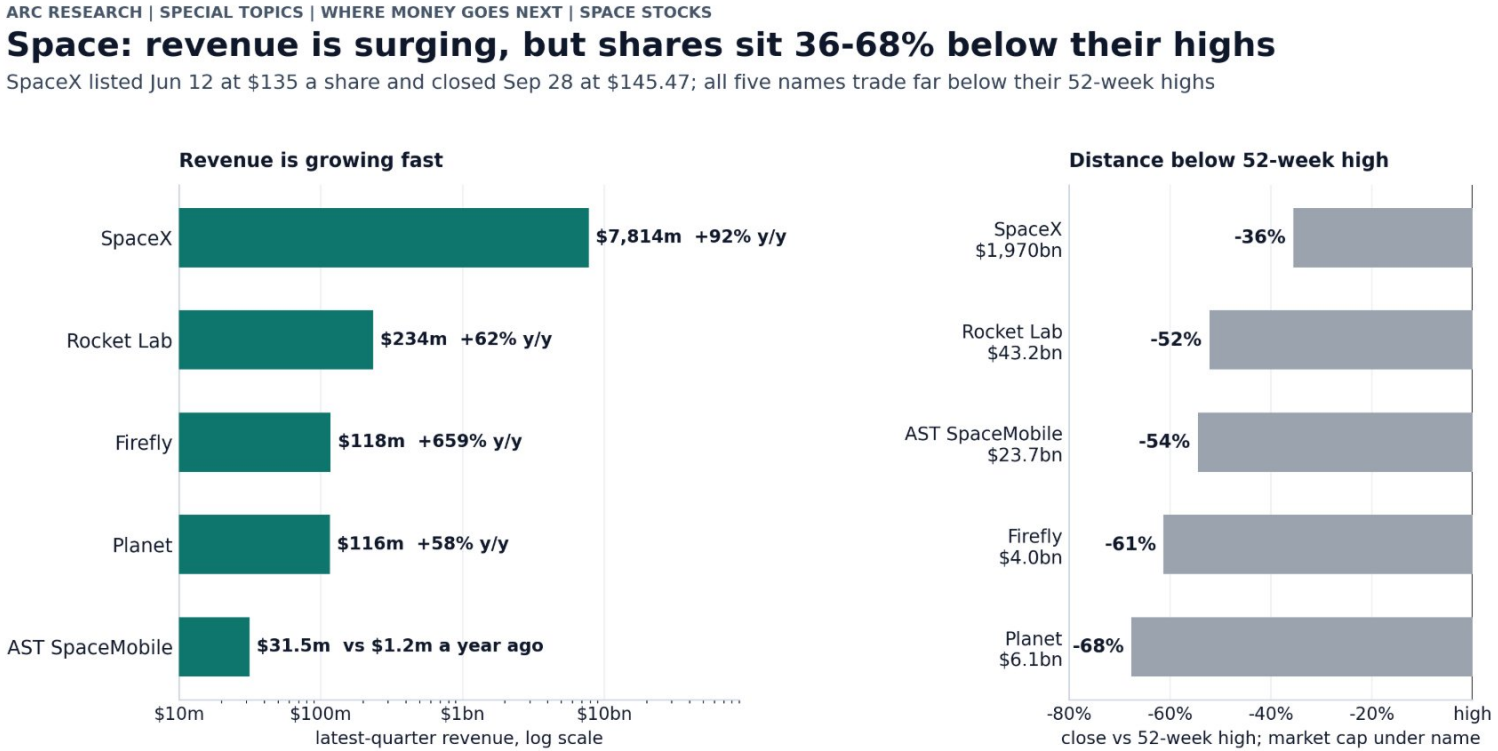
SO WHAT

Long-term uranium: $96.50/lb, +8% in 2026

Meta up to 6.6 GW; Amazon-Talen 1.9 GW

URA -13%, NLR -22% in one year (aggregator)

Space: sales are surging, shares are well off highs



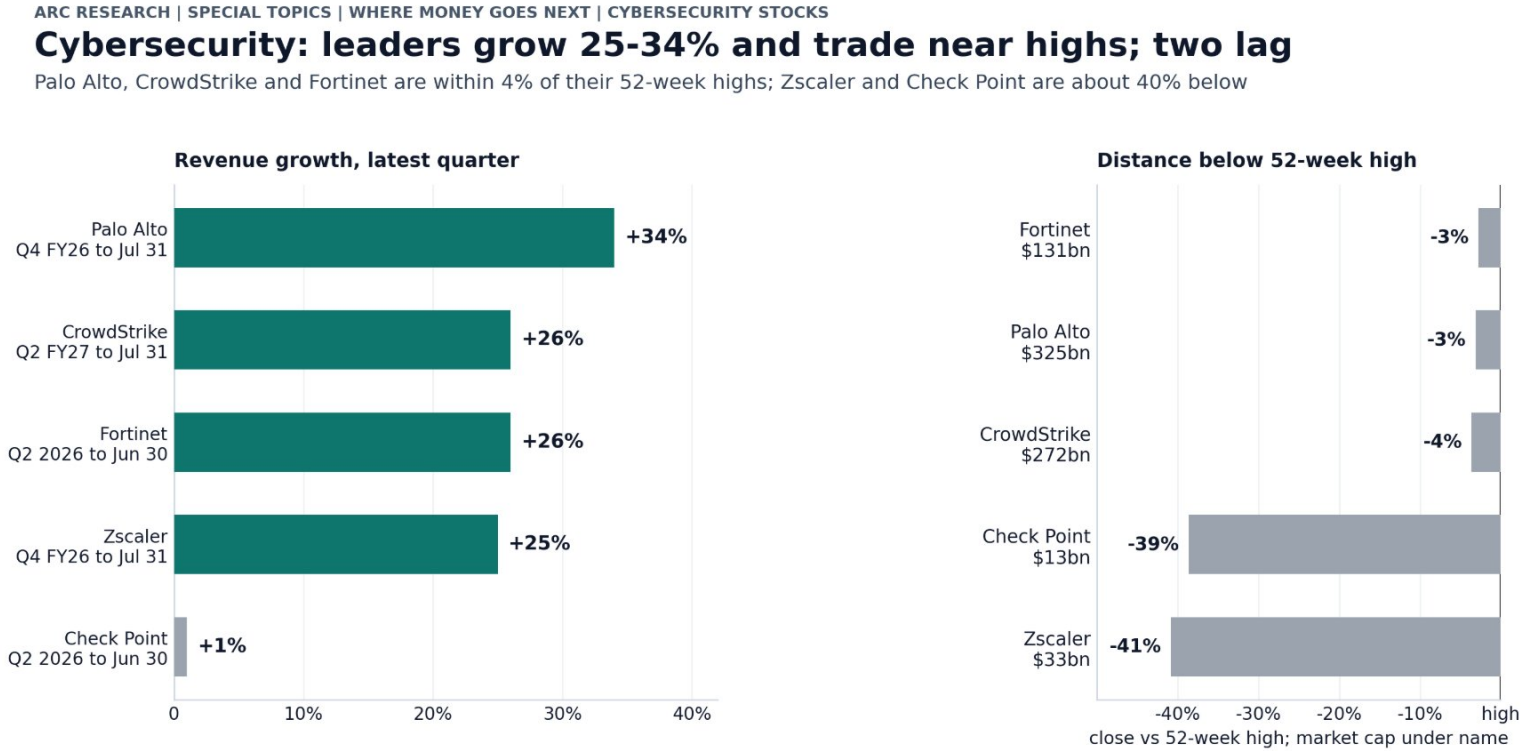
SO WHAT

SpaceX Q2 sales $7.8bn, +92%; it listed Jun 12

Rocket Lab backlog $2.36bn; Neutron still pending

All five trade 36-68% below 52-week highs

Cyber leaders grow 25-34% and sit near highs



Source: left, latest quarterly earnings releases (Palo Alto Sep 1, 2026; CrowdStrike Aug 26; Zscaler Sep 3; Fortinet Jul 29; Check Point Jul 30), total revenue growth year over year as reported; quarter ends differ (Jul 31 for Palo Alto, CrowdStrike, Zscaler; Jun 30 for Fortinet and Check Point). Right: closing prices Sep 28, 2026, 52-week highs and market caps (Sep 30 close) from StockAnalysis (aggregator); distance from high = close / 52-week high - 1 (our calculation); the 52-week high may be intraday.

SO WHAT

Palo Alto +34%, CrowdStrike +26%

Three of five within 4% of highs

Zscaler and Check Point 39-41% below

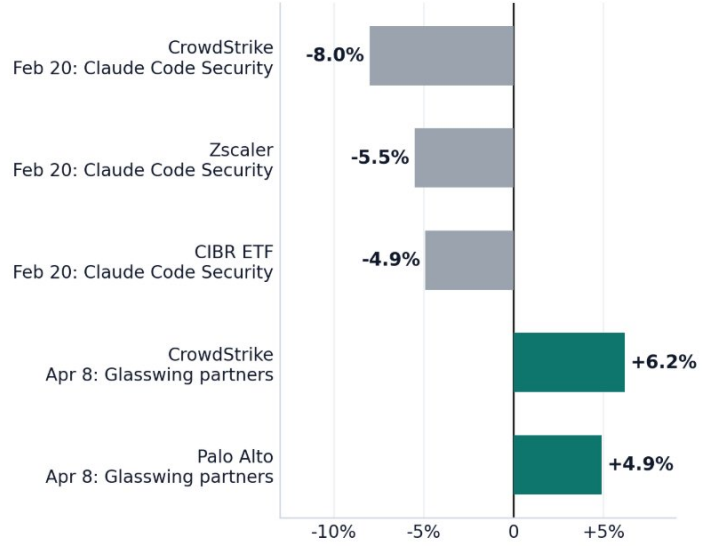
LLMs raise the threat, the demand and the disruption risk

ARC RESEARCH | SPECIAL TOPICS | WHERE MONEY GOES NEXT | CYBERSECURITY AND LLMS

LLMs raise the threat and the demand; they also threaten point products

The same AI news sent cyber stocks down on Feb 20 and up on Apr 8, 2026; attackers are faster and defenders save money with AI

Same technology, opposite days



What AI changes for security

+89%
operations by AI-enabled adversaries in 2025
CrowdStrike threat report

29 min
average eCrime breakout time, 65% faster than 2024
CrowdStrike threat report

$1.93m
breach cost saved with extensive AI and automation
IBM 2026 report

10,000+
high or critical vulnerabilities found by Mythos Preview at partners
Anthropic Glasswing update

Source: left, stock moves on the day, press-reported (Bloomberg, Feb 20, 2026, via search summary; StockTwits, Apr 8, 2026). Right: CrowdStrike 2026 Global Threat Report (Feb 24, 2026); IBM Cost of a Data Breach 2026 (global average $4.99m; saving vs organizations using none); Anthropic, Project Glasswing initial update (May 22, 2026), partners' combined finding. Anthropic, the maker of Claude, launched Claude Code Security and Project Glasswing. CIBR is a cybersecurity ETF.

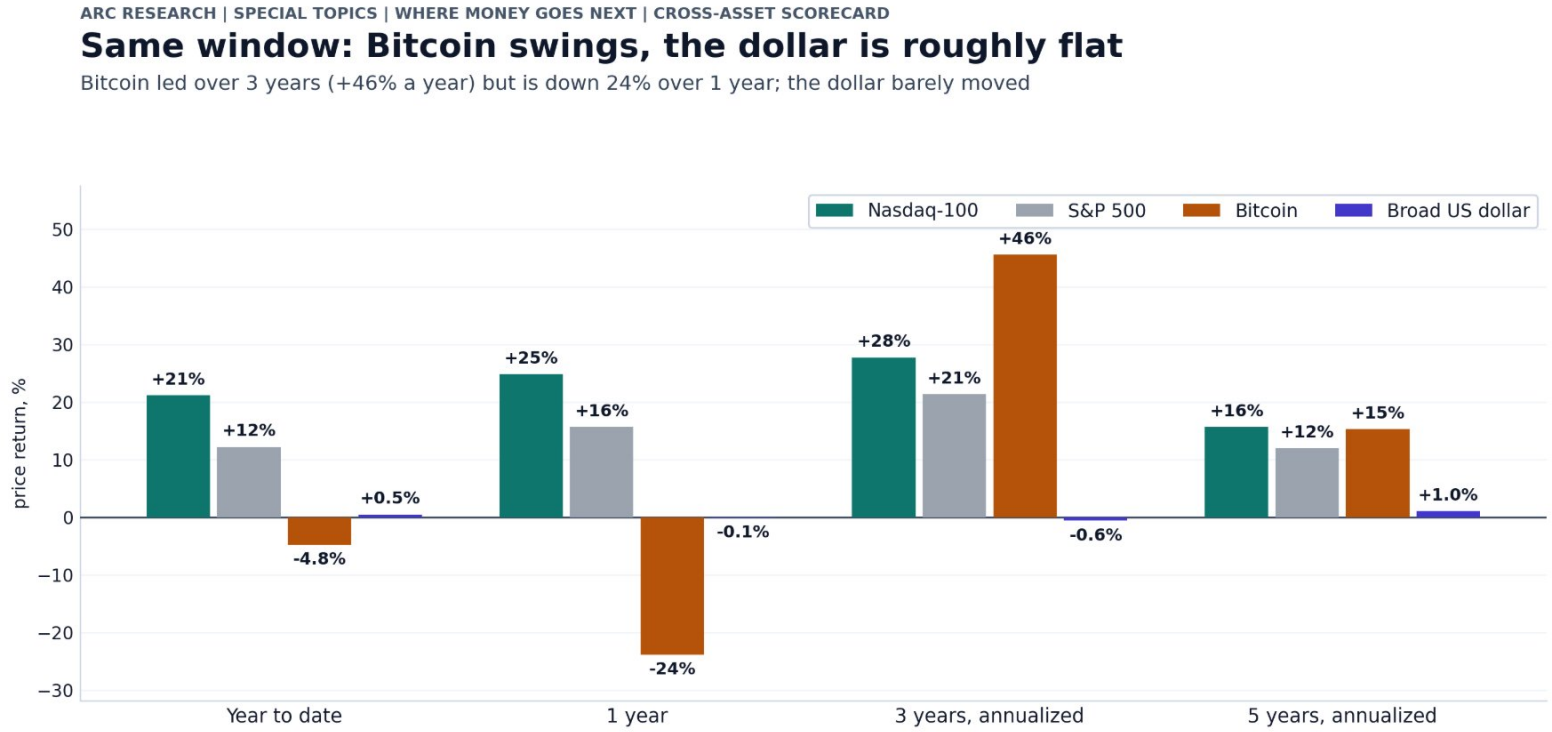
SO WHAT

Attackers use AI: operations +89%

Defenders using AI saved $1.93m a breach

Same AI news: stocks -8% then +6%

Same window: Bitcoin swings, the dollar is flat



SO WHAT

Nasdaq-100: +25% in 1 year, +28% a year over 3

Bitcoin: -24% in 1 year, +46% a year over 3

Broad dollar: -0.1% in 1 year

ARC Research view (a view, not advice)

Less dollar cash. Keep US tech. Add hard assets.

Exposure	Role	Needs to go right	What breaks it
US tech	Growth engine	AI demand holds	Capex pause, concentration
Gold and silver	Dollar hedge	Central banks keep buying	Real rates rise
Nuclear, uranium	Power scarcity	Deals become contracts	Equities keep lagging
Emerging markets	Cheaper growth	Chip cycle continues	Chip downturn, tariffs
Crypto	Non-dollar option	Adoption, clear rules	Deep drawdowns

Sources

AI, US tech, energy

Microsoft, Amazon, Meta Q2 2026 releases

SEC EDGAR XBRL: 10-K financials, five tech names

Nvidia Q2 FY27 release, Aug 26, 2026

FactSet Earnings Insight, Sep 25, 2026

FRED: NASDAQ100, SP500

IEA: Energy and AI (2025), Key Questions (2026)

LBNL / DOE data-centre report, Dec 2024

PJM 2028/29 auction, Jul 14, 2026; EIA STEO

Nuclear and emerging markets

Cameco uranium prices (UxC / TradeTech)

Constellation, Talen, Kairos, Meta releases

MSCI factsheets, Aug 31, 2026

World Bank population projections; Taiwan NDC

TSMC and SK hynix Q2 2026 results

SpaceX 8-K, Rocket Lab, Firefly, Planet, AST releases

Debt, dollar, metals, crypto

US Treasury, Debt to the Penny, Sep 24, 2026

FRED: FYPUGDA188S, FYOIGDA188S, FYOINT, DTWEXBGS

CBO Budget and Economic Outlook, Feb 2026

IMF WEO Apr 2026 (G7 debt, deficits) and Jul 2026 Update; COFER Q1 2026

World Gold Council, Gold Demand Trends

Silver Institute via Blockport (press-reported)

FRED: CBBTCUSD; DefiLlama (aggregator)

Strategy 8-K, Sep 14, 2026; GENIUS Act, PL 119-27

TRM Labs on x402, Sep 9, 2026; x402 Foundation (Linux Foundation)

Press-reported or aggregator

Alphabet capex, silver, URA and NLR returns, Korea and Taiwan trade data, space-stock prices (StockAnalysis)